بَـــــرَكاتُ مِـــنْ فِلَسْـــطِينَ
Blessings from Palestine



Blessings from Palestine:
Reclaiming heritage through the jewellery and amulets of Palestine

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Abstract

This research explores the reclamation and reinterpretation of Palestinian material culture, focusing on traditional jewellery and amulets as both containers and expressions of cultural knowledge, resilience, and identity. Through processes of contemporary ceramic practices, my work engages with historical objects to breathe life into them, making them relevant and accessible in the present.

Framed within the concept of "heritage in the making," the research moves beyond cultural preservation to emphasize heritage as a dynamic, relational resource that bridges the past and future while addressing contemporary cultural needs. By integrating design, craft, and storytelling, the thesis investigates how material culture can serve as a means fostering cultural identity and resilience in the face of historical and ongoing erasure.

Through material processes this work aims to transform heritage from static memory into a living, tangible expression of identity, offering an active resource for belonging, reflection, and enabling the continuation of creative cultural expressions. In a time marked by pervasive destruction, this research seeks to portray beauty, resilience and endurance.

Keywords: Cultural Heritage, Palestinian Heritage, Material Culture, Ceramics, Contemporary Craft, Jewellery and Amulets, Belonging, Heritage in the Making, Identity, Resilience

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Introduction

I write this essay during times of war on Gaza. Amid the massive loss of human life and displacement in Gaza, along with the loss of human lives, cultural heritage is also being wiped out and destroyed[1]. As I bear witness to the thousands of lives lost in the past months, I also grieve the destruction of the cultural heritage of the collective that carries the accumulated knowledge of our shared ancestors. I wonder how much loss and damage can be described as collateral?

Making and researching Palestinian material culture feels insignificant in the face of such immense human loss and destruction. Yet, I have come to realize that, now more than ever, the act of creating and bringing something new into existence is important. It is in fact a small act of resilience in the face of systematic destruction.

Cultural objects are closely connected to the lives of the people who made and used them, reflecting their values, beliefs, and fears in tangible manifestations. Throughout history, Palestinians have sought refuge in their faith for resilience in the face of the unknown. Many of these objects, like amulets and jewellery, provided comfort and protection, easing restlessness and offering a sense of stability in times of uncertainty.



Image 1: Jerusalem 1950

[1] More than 200 ancient cultural or archaeological sites had been destroyed according to a report published by the NGO Heritage for Peace and UNESCO.

Background

I write in the voice of a curious young Palestinian woman, an indigenous Jerusalemite, a designer, a maker, a ceramicist, a researcher, a privileged yet stateless individual searching for her sense of belonging, a belonging that extends beyond geography. In my experience, the presence of Palestinian material culture and heritage has been largely absent throughout my life as a Palestinian living in Jerusalem. Moreover, this cultural presence is systematically being erased, destroyed and gradually disappearing. I still remember the moment when my eyes fell on historical Palestinian cultural objects and how I stood in awe of their beauty and richness. I felt privileged to have found them despite them being tucked away in the back of souvenir shops, since they did not find their way to coexist with the contemporary complex reality that we live in. These items full of dust peeking at me from the past, still maintained their power to connect me with my deepest sense of identity.

In my journey of research and making, through ceramic processes, I explore how I can reclaim protection and heritage by re-interpreting and engaging with the tangible remnants of Palestinian material culture, particularly traditional jewellery and amulets. Through my practice, I investigate how reconnecting with heritage and the knowledge it holds can nourish my sense of belonging and identity, building on heritage to honour the past, inspiring the present, and paving the way for the future.

Of the wide range of material heritage of Palestine, I have chosen amulets and jewellery as my medium into exploring Palestinian identity in its cultural heritage context. I am intrigued by these objects that served as a medium to anchor a haven on earth. They are most meaningful for me today as I witnessed the war that has stripped us from any human and cultural resources that can sustain us and allow us to be resilient. I am intrigued by these objects, beyond their ornamental value. I believe that these objects, filled with blessings and protection, carry the truest intentions, deepest desires, and beliefs of their makers and wearers. I experience them as containers of knowledge, objects that integrate invisible forces into the earthly world, offering comfort, protection, sense of control, and easing restlessness in the face of the unknown.

Before I dive in, I feel the need to take a step back. A coherent understanding of Palestinian identity, cultural heritage, and its material culture cannot be achieved without an exploration within the broader context of its history. Looking through the lenses of history, we find that the interconnectedness of Palestine with its past and its broader regional context transcends both ancient and modern national borders. We also encounter the particular Palestinian strength that resides in the traditional cultural and religious pluralism that shaped the history of this land. Sadly, looking through the eyes of the ongoing present - we observe that Palestinians have been subject to continuous colonisation for many decades, having a persistent and ongoing impact on its cultural and social fabric causing disruptions to the organic development of the land, the inhabitants and their identity.[2]

[2] Nazmi Al-Ju'beh, "Palestinian Identity and Cultural Heritage," in Temps et Espaces En Palestine (Presses de l'Ifpo, 2008), 205–31.

Cultural heritage and historical context

In Palestine, every stone tells a story, every artefact holds secrets of generations long gone. Material culture in this land is not just a collection of objects; it is the living heritage of centuries of accumulated cultural experience, shaped over time through people's interactions with their environment and other cultures. These objects hold cultural significance, reflecting the values, traditions, beliefs, and practices of the people who created and used them.

To begin with, certain elements must be clarified before we can present contemporary Palestinian identity in its cultural heritage context: Palestine, Palestinians, borders, historical context, colonial impact and the different components of the identity. To understand Palestine's material culture, we must understand the components that have shaped it. In other words, the Palestinian people[3] are not different from other Greater Syria (Bilad al-Sham) people. As meticulously expressed by archaeologist and historian Al-Jubeh, the Palestinian identity is the result of accumulated influences from various ethnic, racial, and religious groups who lived, conquered, occupied, or passed through this strip of land. Wars and invasions never fully replaced the local population; rather, they added to, mixed with, and reformulated the local identity. Regardless of the extent to which they affected the land and its people, they all left their touch in shaping the Palestinian identity.

This raises the question: what, then, makes the Palestinians who they are?

The most accurate perspective I have encountered comes from Nazmi Al-Jubeh: "The Palestinian people are the Canaanites, the Philistines, the Jebusites, the Assyrians, the Babylonians, the Egyptians, the Aramaeans, the Greeks, the Romans, the Byzantines, the Arabs, the Turks, the Crusaders, and the Kurds, who once settled, conquered, occupied or just passed through Palestine"[4]

Considering the rich heritage of previous civilisations that have shaped the present Palestinian identity, the people of Palestine have had a long experience in the process of engagement with the land, thus producing from it a rich cultural heritage, which became an essential part of their being. This material culture reflects the creativity of the indigenous people who have manifested great skill in benefiting from the land and its resources to create objects for their daily life. The tangible and intangible material heritage of Palestine includes archaeological and historical sites, vernacular architecture, holy shrines, sanctuaries, folkloric songs, dances like the Dabke, clothing and intricate embroidery (Tatreez), instruments and tools used for daily life, self adornment objects, jewellery, as well as a rich collection of amulets. This cultural heritage is connected to both individual and collective memory. Its true value stems from the fact that Palestine actually represents—through folk norms and material culture — the living heritage of all the accumulated ancient cultures that appeared in Palestine.

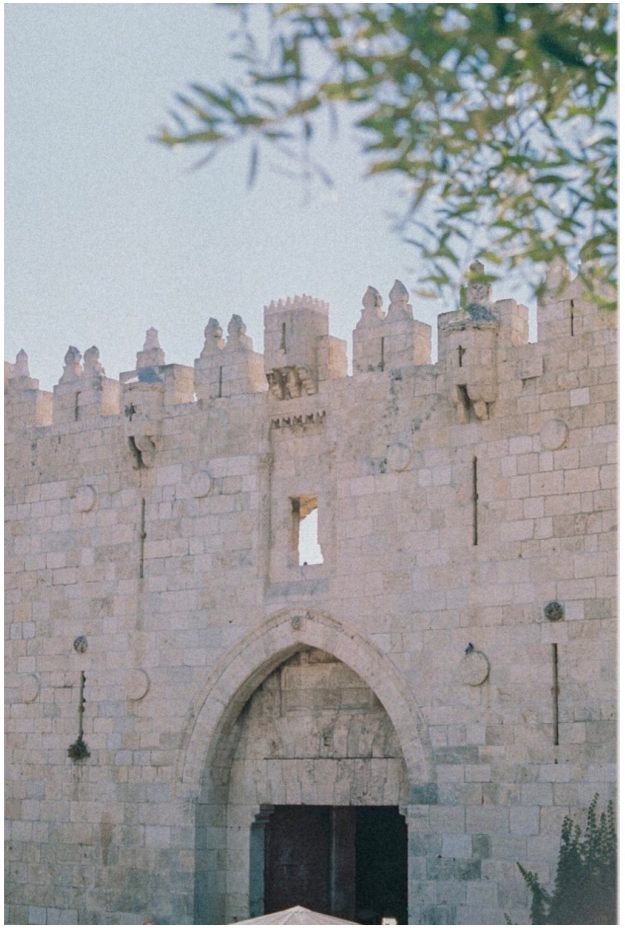


Image 2: Damascus Gate, Jerusalem[5]

[3] Greater Syria or Bilad al-Sham, encompassing Jordan, Palestine, Syria, and Lebanon. (Referred to as the Levant, by the West deriving its name from the French meaning "where the sun rises")
[4] Nazmi Al-Ju'beh, "Palestinian Identity and Cultural Heritage," in Temps et Espaces En Palestine (Presses de l'Ifpo, 2008), 205–31.

[5] One of the entrances to the Old City of Jerusalem, you can notice stone layers of various architectural styles. The distinct layers of stones in the wall reflect the different periods of construction built by different civilisations, from the Romans to the Ottomans and everyone who came between, each contributing to the architectural heritage of the site.

After diving into the rich, centuries-old history of Palestinian heritage, let's fast-forward to the 20th century—long history short—where political upheavals and displacement began to fragment this cultural heritage in ways that still resonate today, with ongoing occupation further fragmenting and disrupting its continuity. During the first part of the 20th century, the land area of Palestine underwent several changes, beginning from the Sykes-Picot[6] agreement which imposed artificial borders dividing Bilad al Sham - a region that had historically never experienced national borders. This division isolated the indigenous peoples of this region from their long shared history of having geographic and ethnic diversity and fluidity. During this period, known as the British Mandate period, Palestinians were aspiring for statehood which was derailed by the establishment of the state of Israel[7]. Along with its people, land, culture, and history, Palestine underwent a catastrophe known as Al-Nakba[8], in 1948 and the subsequent years. A large segment of the Palestinian people were forcibly displaced, hundreds of Palestinian villages and towns were destroyed, resulting in the theft of their homes, belongings, and land. This led to nearly 800,000 people being uprooted, with 531 villages destroyed and eleven urban neighborhoods emptied of their inhabitants, resulting in more than half of Palestine's native population becoming refugees beyond the borders of their ancestral homeland.[9] In the process, the traces of countless villages, towns, and cities were erased, wiping out their mosques, churches, shrines, and all their material cultural heritage.

The Palestinian people, spaces and culture suffered and continue to suffer tremendous and mostly irreversible losses through these waves of destruction. Most components of cultural heritage-based identity were lost through the separation of the indigenous people from their lived practices and traditions, spaces and resources. This destructive process continued to the Occupied Territories in 1967[10] and has only picked up speed since the Oslo Accords.[11] This rupture in cultural continuity not only erased physical heritage and spaces but also disrupted the intergenerational transmission of knowledge, practices, and traditions, leaving a void in the collective conscious that Palestinians continue to grapple with today. Palestinians today require in their dramatically changing landscape different kinds of reminders to fill in their 'imagination' with memories of the past.[12]

[6] France and Britain defined the borders according to their needs as well as interest in creating a Jewish homeland as outlined in the Balfour Declaration.
[7] Rashid Khalidi, The Hundred Years' War on Palestine: A History of Settler Colonialism and Resistance, 1917–2017 (Metropolitan Books, 2020).
[8] In Arabic, 'Al-Nakba' means "catastrophe", referring to the mass displacement, dispossession and ethnic cleansing of Palestine and the near-total destruction of Palestinian society in 1948.
[9] Ilan Pappe, The Ethnic Cleansing of Palestine (Simon and Schuster, 2007).
[10] The 1967 Palestinian exodus, in Arabic 'naksa' means "setback" referring to the displacement of Palestinians out of the territories (West bank and Gaza) captured by Israel during and in the aftermath of the 1967 War.
[11] The Oslo Accords, signed in the 1990s between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), aimed to establish a framework for peace and Palestinian self -governance. However, the accords ultimately failed to resolve key issues, such as the status of Jerusalem, borders, and refugees.
[12] Khaldun Bshara, "Heritage in Palestine: Colonial Legacy in Postcolonial Discourse," Archaeologies 9, no. 2 (August 2013): 311.



Image 3: ruins of Manshiya neighborhood in Jaffa 1948[13]

[13] The ruins of one of Jaffa's neighborhoods in 1948 mirror the destruction in Gaza in 2024, decades apart, both showing systematic erasure, reducing Palestinian landscapes to rubble. Modern-day Tel Aviv was built over these ruins, with the mosque standing as the sole surviving structure from the past.

Understanding the present

Like any threatened indigenous people, who find themselves in a continuous identity struggle with stronger groups or states, they inevitably undergo a process of reformulating, reshaping, and restructuring of its identity. Despite the fragmentation in Palestinian existence, the culture has continued to thrive under the different aspects of the colonial project, resulting in its complex contemporary expression.[14] Consequently, the Palestinian struggle to maintain their historical and cultural identity in the face of colonial narrative and domination undoubtedly had a tremendous negative impact on the Palestinian people as a whole, and their sense of identity.

As subjects of colonialism and occupation, Palestinians unknowingly underwent processes employed by colonisers to manipulate, distort, erase and alienate them from their identity and heritage. These processes, as presented by architect and anthropologist Khaldun Bshara[15], can be understood through the concepts of falafelization, falsification, alienation, and estrangement. By breaking down each aspect, we understand how cultural appropriation, distortion, alienation, and estrangement have affected Palestinian heritage, highlighting the ongoing effects of colonialism on Palestinian identity.

In his writings, Khaldun Bshara introduces the concept of "Falafelisation"[16], which refers to the appropriation of Palestinian culture by colonial powers. This process involves the claiming and incorporation of the indigenous heritage into the new colonial regime. Examples of this include renaming indigenous traditions such as local cuisine, embroidery, sacred places, shrines, and building arts. Through "Falafelisation," colonisers seek to assert control over Palestinian identity and heritage, erasing the indigenous culture's autonomy and significance in the process. Whatever survives the process of falafelisation acquires a stigmatised reputation: primitive, backward, and uncivilised.

The second process of "Falsification," involves the distortion of history by the colonialist to favour a particular biased narrative. This includes the rewriting of history books to promote a new storyline portraying the landscape as inherently empty, devoid of indigenous presence. Simultaneously, this process is also accompanied with a new narrative that brings a cohesive, long and continuous narrative of fragmented presence, while at the same time it wipes out the obvious continuity of indigenous people's material culture and embodied practices.

[14] This complex contemporary expression blends traditional elements with new forms shaped by the struggles of modern-day Palestinians. Influenced by historical context, political realities, and the need to balance heritage preservation with adaptation, these cultural forms reflect resilience, loss, and resistance in the face of ongoing struggles.

[15] Khaldun Bshara, “Heritage in Palestine: Colonial Legacy in Postcolonial Discourse,” Archaeologies 9, no. 2 (August 2013): 295–319. Khaldun Bshara is a Palestinian architect, restorer, and anthropologist renowned for his work in preserving and documenting Palestinian heritage.

[16] Falafel is fried balls of ground chickpeas mixed with herbs and spices: “falafelization” a term invented by Khaldun Bshara in reference to the fierce battle between Palestinians and Israelis on the origin of falafel and hummus. Bshara, “Heritage in Palestine,” 300.

The process of "Alienation" as explored in Bshara's paper draws from postcolonial theory. In this framework, alienation refers to separation of indigenous Palestinians from their common spaces, which is essential in meaning-making practices and sustaining their value systems. This form of alienation disrupts Palestinians' sense of belonging and agency within their communities and societies. Through this lens, Bshara examines how this process denies Palestinians the freedom necessary for upholding cultural values and social structures.[17]

As an outcome, under the lens of what Bshara calls “Estrangement”, Palestinians find themselves born into a world that already has its own meanings, written by the colonialist. They have not only lost their material culture, but also they are not allowed to talk about it nor question the history that made them lose it. This form of estrangement, also termed debilitating alienation or double alienation[18] within the context of Palestinian heritage leaves individuals unable to reflect, contemplate, or express their ideas of the world - making this type of alienation debilitating and traumatic. Palestinians suffer a double alienation when they do not possess the tools to defend and understand their culture, their everyday practices, and their belonging. As the late Palestinian scholar Edward W. Said keenly noted, “facts do not at all speak for themselves, but require a socially acceptable narrative to absorb, sustain and circulate them.”[19]



Image 4: This piece of embroidery (tatreez), originally part of a traditional thobe dress, has been transformed into a pillowcase cover. The pattern features embroidered amulets.

[17] Bshara, “Heritage in Palestine,”: 301-302.

[18] Bshara, “Heritage in Palestine,”: 302.

[19] Edward Said, “Permission to Narrate,” Journal of Palestine Studies 13, no. 3 (April 1984): 27–48.

Being incapable of stopping the continued and accelerating erasure of the two greatest archives of all: the physical and the landscape, Palestinians employed heritage to knit a national identity that is also material. In doing so, they have sought to affirm their connection to the land which is also connected in fundamental ways to the loss of that land. The result being that Palestine has been transformed into a set of abstract symbols devoid of the distinct meanings and detached from material practices. What once was an integral part of everyday life – from clothing to rituals and customs – has been turned into a set of symbols in a desperate attempt to salvage any relics from the disappearing past.

Despite the intricate connection between Palestinian heritage and nationhood, it is important to not focus on cultural heritage solely as an inheritance of nationhood. In doing so we run the risk of reducing it to a functional category that serves the creation of national identity. In the nationalists point of view, the physical remains of the past—such as the archaeological traces of ancient societies—are transformed into national symbols.[20] Adopting this view in the Palestinians case would wrongly mean that the cultural heritage is not a shared resource but an instrument of subjugation in which we are not only disfranchised in the present but in the past.

Today, everyday contemporary Palestinian heritage objects have become an ancestral accessory - decoration for a table, a corner, or a wall of a house, offering a sense of timeless tradition at weddings, their cultural depth reduced to aesthetics in the luxury market. Meanwhile, their producers face exploitation, and their craft is undervalued, stripped of its significance and reduced to a commodity. This commodification may reflect a collective effort to hold onto memories of a lost past, grieving what has been lost while trying to preserve elements of cultural heritage and identity. The forces driving this transformation are complex: on one hand, they reflect the desire to preserve cultural identity, as people seek connection and belonging through them. On the other hand, as they become consumable goods, severing the link between the objects and the practices that once gave them life and significance. As Bshara observes, “In light of the continuous preoccupation with great issues (such as liberation) or with everyday concerns (such as making a living), Palestinians find themselves consumed in battle after battle against an entire system of research, education, knowledge production, and colonial propaganda.”[21]

Building on the discussions in this chapter, The different circumstances and processes of colonialisation and oppression have led to a disconnect between the material culture and the people it once served, leaving behind a heritage that feels detached of well-defined dimensions, often appearing fragmented, lost, and alienated. Many aspects, such as traditional crafts and objects of cultural significance seem stuck or frozen in the past, stripped of their original context. Consequently, this creates a blurry and ambiguous portrayal of Palestinian cultural identity, making it difficult to fully understand its authenticity and continuity, Yet, in this ambiguity lies the potential for reclamation.

[20] Nazmi Al-Jubeh, “What Matters? Considering the Future of Cultural Heritage in Palestine,” Present Pasts 2, no. 1 (August 15, 2010).
[21] Khaldun Bshara. “Marvels of Despair The Status of Cultural Heritage in Palestine.” This Week In Palestine, no. 277 (May 2021): 54–60.

I sometimes wonder how the material culture of Palestine could have evolved today, had it been allowed to naturally develop, protected from the infiltration of mass-produced objects and the forces of globalisation and colonialism. The natural flow of cultural practices, objects, and heritage could have led to a distinct and continuously evolving identity, rather than the one that exists now, shaped by external disruptions.



Image 5: Ceramic head-chain al-zard (stoneware, 2024)

Heritage in the making

The concept and definition of heritage continues to grow within the field of heritage studies. Richard Sandford[22], Professor of Heritage Evidence, defines heritage as encompassing both tangible and intangible aspects of culture, identity, and memory, passed down through generations. He emphasizes that heritage is not static but a dynamic and evolving process shaped by the context and values of each era. Drawing on the work of Holtorf and Kristensen, Sandford reframes heritage as a site of continuous transformation, influenced by both natural processes and human intervention.

Expanding of this perspective, Laurajane Smith[23], Professor of Heritage and Museum Studies, explains that heritage is a cultural process of active identity construction. She highlights how heritage is transmitted across generations, carrying with it transferring values and meanings while accumulating new ones in the present. Smith stresses that emblems of heritage must be constantly re-evaluated and redefined to remain relevant, based on the evolving needs and contexts of the present.

Sandford emphasizes that heritage is inherently forward-looking. He proposes that "thinking with heritage" allows communities to articulate futures that are meaningful and worth striving for, shifting the question from "What will happen?" to "What do we care about, and how do we carry it forward?"[24] This approach encourages active engagement with the future by grounding it in the present values and practices, encouraging us to see heritage not just as a reflection of the past but as a living resource for shaping futures rooted in those very traditions.

Stanford also highlights heritage as a relational practice, embedded in social and geographic contexts. He introduces the concept of a "regime of care"[25], where people and heritage objects are intertwined, shaping and being shaped by the futures they help form. This view underscores the importance of considering how heritage objects participate in ongoing processes of cultural and personal identity formation.

In the Palestinian context, this evolving perspective on heritage is particularly urgent as the Palestinian people continue to experience ongoing systematic erasure of cultural identity which challenges the continuity of cultural traditions and knowledge. The loss of heritage is not only the disappearance of physical objects but the erosion of cultural memory and knowledge itself. However, heritage holds the potential to address contemporary needs and authenticity. By engaging with heritage in a dynamic way, Palestinians can reclaim and maintain cultural practices as part of a continuous process of cultural expression, ensuring that their heritage remains relevant in shaping a meaningful future.

Finally, Sandford suggests that heritage should not be seen as a fixed history but as an evolving process of reinterpretation. Cultural objects are continuously redefined to meet the needs of the community, ensuring that heritage remains relevant, participatory, and capable of shaping identity, agency, and belonging across generations. For Palestinians, engaging with heritage dynamically offers resilience amidst systemic challenges.

As heritage is continually redefined and reshaped through dynamic processes, craft emerges as a practice that both embodies these transformations and actively sustains the living, evolving essence of cultural identity.

Exploring this relationship, Juliette MacDonald, Professor of Craft History and Theory highlights the role of craft as an essential process for articulating experiences and perceptions. She argues that the continuation or creation of communities of practice is vital for valuing cultural identity. Through craft, we can relate to the past, examine the present, and project who we might be in the future.[26] Craft, as a practice, becomes a bridge between heritage and identity, allowing individuals and communities to actively engage with their cultural legacy. By creating and sustaining communities of practice, craft ensures that heritage is not only preserved but actively lived and reimagined. In this way, craft and heritage are interconnected. Craft provides a tangible means of engaging with heritage, transforming it from an abstract concept into a lived experience.

In line with this understanding of craft and heritage, Khaldun Bshara further points that engaging, reimagining and interpreting historic objects and spaces have become mediums for Palestinian artists, architects, and designers to reclaim their agency allowing them to practice what the colonial once prohibited, planning the future. By engaging with spatial and cultural questions, they transform their heritage into a tool for resilience, reclaiming their right to shape their world. As Bshara states "they are no longer thrown into a world to inhabit; rather, this world is waiting for them to shape and change it."[27]

Building on the previous insights, my approach in crafting reinterpreted objects inspired by Palestinian jewellery and amulets aligns with a forward-looking view of heritage. I like to refer to this approach as "heritage in the making", a process of actively shaping and reclaiming cultural heritage through contemporary craft practices. Through craft, these containers of cultural knowledge find a way to evolve alongside contemporary needs and contexts allowing us to reclaim cultural belonging in a way that reflects our values and aspirations today. The making becomes an active participant that resonates with current needs as well as in crafting meaningful and resilient future with the wisdom of the past ensuring continuity across time.

[22] Richard Sandford, "Thinking with Heritage: Past and Present in Lived Futures," Futures 111 (August 2019): 71–80.
[23] Laurajane Smith, Uses of Heritage (Routledge, 2006). 303.
[24] Sandford, "Thinking with Heritage," PDF page 18.
[25] Sandford, "Thinking with Heritage," PDF page 16.

[26] Juliette MacDonald, "Hunting for lost crafts," in Craft and Heritage: Intersections in Critical Studies and Practice, ed. Susan Surette and Elaine Cheasley Paterson (London: Bloomsbury Publishing, 2021), 265-266.
[27] Bshara, "Heritage in Palestine," 314.

Small blessings

Across the history of Palestine, women have used a wide range of objects—from jewellery and amulets to ritual objects—filled with blessings and protection, carrying the truest intentions, values and beliefs of their makers and wearers. They were objects of resilience that helped people integrate invisible forces into the earthly world, creating comfort, protection, and a sense of control, while easing restlessness in the face of the unknown.

My interest as an artist and a researcher revolves around this particular group of objects—used as a means to protect from evil and misfortune, to avert and heal disease, and to invoke good luck and blessings. These objects are a valuable source of knowledge for exploring identity, culture and beliefs of the people of Palestine as they are profoundly linked with the local religion and Palestinian cultural beliefs. Such objects offer alternative perspectives on the past that have not been recorded in textual sources, they provide a window into the soul of a society, like language itself, as a medium of exchange, an instrument for communication, reflection, and the formation of identity.

When I look at these objects today, I experience them as containers of knowledge, offering insights into the social, cultural, and spiritual fabric of the society that created them.

Despite being somewhat forgotten in the collective memory of Palestinians, these objects provide valuable knowledge on an essential part of the Palestinian people's identity, culture and beliefs as they are profoundly linked with the local religion and Palestinian popular beliefs and practices. Objects that are the material component of values that their makers and wearers or users believed in. They were used by the fellahin[28], bedouin and townspeople in Palestine.

In the context of this culture, the category of amulet is applied to objects such as jewellery that can be worn or carried on their body, but also objects and texts that are placed on land crops to assure fertility or placed at home to protect them and their occupants as well as clothes that have amulets functions. In 1948, most Palestinian jewellery and amulets moved with refugees to Jordan, Lebanon, Syria, and further abroad. Much of it was sold to cover survival needs or passage to a safer place. Along with the jewellery, the prominent silversmith families from Jerusalem and Bethlehem were also displaced or immigrated, and their craft eventually was lost along the way.[29]

Based on my understanding and observations, since the 20th century collections and collectors have been the main places holding heritage objects of this region. The remaining historical examples of Palestinian jewellery and amulets are housed in museum collections, private collections or kept by those who have inherited them.



Image 6: Palestinian jewellery displayed at the Yasser Barakat Gallery in the Old city of Jerusalem[30]

[28] A fellah - plural fellahin, are indigenous rural villagers. The word derives from the Arabic word for "ploughman" or "tiller". They constituted the majority of the population in 1948.

[29] This information is based on oral knowledge shared with me by a shop owner and collector in Jerusalem who has extensive knowledge in Palestinian heritage.

[30] The Yasser Barakat Gallery, located in the Old City of Jerusalem, is a place I visit to explore jewellery and heritage objects and to learn from the owner along the way. It exists as something in between a shop and a gallery. Among its displays, Palestinian jewellery is arranged in every little space available, with some pieces for sale, while others are marked "not for sale" as the owner wishes to preserve them as personal treasures.



Image 7: Iznaq 'seven souls' silver chin chain, consists of seven connected short chains, ending with two chains to attach to the headdress. At the bottom there is a hollowed out silver ball 'jerusalem bead' and a large Maria Theresa coin from 1780.



Image 8: Face veil from the nomad people of the Naqab region made of textiles, silver toned metal and beads.

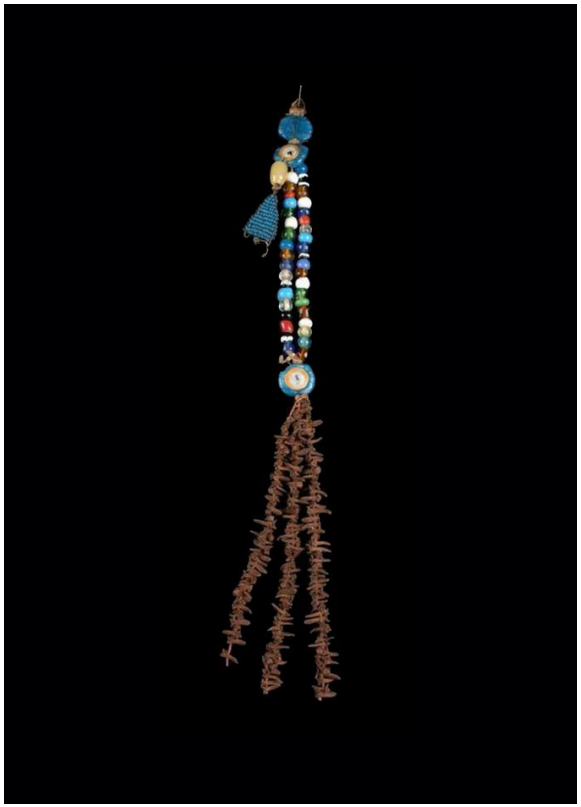


Image 9: An amulet pendant 'qladet qrunful' with coloured glass beads, an evil eye 'awayneh' and cloves. Made between 1900-1930.

It is relevant to mention the Tawfik Canaan[31] Collection of Palestinian amulets. In his collection, Canaan collected throughout his life around 1400 objects that he categorised as amulets, ranging from intricate jewellery to seemingly unaltered organic materials. For him, amulets functioned, just as medicine, to reestablish well-being through their healing and protective power. The kinds of power that amulets bear and the ways they convey such power to the users are diverse. Amulets acquire their power first through their shape and form and secondly through their application—and both are adjusted to fit the amulet's function. The specific arrangement of elements on the amulet is achieved by carving, modelling or assembling the materials into symbolic shapes or by inscribing them. In addition, specific materials, like coral and cloves, contributed to the amulets' power, as they were believed to possess protective qualities. Some amulets exerted their power simply by being worn or being in place. Others could only be activated by reading the text written on them.[32] For example, in image 7, you can see a clove pendant necklace, or qladet qrunful, from the early 20th century. It consists of a combination of glass beads, glass evil eyes, triangular beaded amulet, cloves, and a linen cord, each element and material carrying significant protective meanings and functions that protects the wearer. The glass Khalili eyes, crafted in Hebron, are believed to ward off the evil eye, protecting the wearer from envy and harmful intentions. Cloves, known for their strong scent, were believed to expel bad spirits, offering further protection.

People's knowledge about specific amulets, the way they are made and used passed through generations by word of mouth. This knowledge is based on the experience of the residents and on how nature behaves throughout the year, how nature has subsumed to become sacred history and how it has become powerful in offering protection and healing. Different forms of knowledge have developed and accumulated throughout time as practices and information were transmitted from one language, religion, culture, period or region to another.[33]

When undertaking this project I started with the archives created by those who came before me, recognizing their importance in preserving material culture, knowledge and memory. However, objects in archives can sometimes leave them stuck in the past, frozen in time. It is not enough to simply collect them and visit them; I believe that it is crucial to actively engage with them, allowing them to become part of our present, ensuring their relevance and connection to the future. For example, traditional Palestinian jewellery and amulets, preserved in archives and collections, can be reimagined and recreated in contemporary forms, making them accessible and meaningful in today's world, offering resilience and indigenous knowledge. Through this process, the objects evolve, allowing us to reclaim and reshape cultural narratives that are relevant to our current lives.

By exploring this category of objects of the Palestinian material culture, we uncover layers of cultural and spiritual knowledge, significance and practices. These objects illustrate how material culture can embody and sustain a people's heritage through time, offering insights into the values, beliefs, and practices that make the Palestinian collective cultural identity.



Image 10: Ramallah Girl, wearing Palestinian costume and jewellery. Circa 1910s-1930s.

[31] Tawfiq Canaan (1882–1964) was a Palestinian physician, medical researcher, and ethnographer, known for his studies on Palestinian folklore, amulets, and cultural heritage.
[32] Baha Al-Jubeh, "Magic and Talismans: The Tawfiq Canaan Collection of Palestinian Amulets," The Jerusalem Quarterly 2 (2005): 105.
[33] Marcela A. Garcia Probert, "Twigs in the Tawfik Canaan Collection of Palestinian Amulets," in Amulets and Talismans of the Middle East and North Africa in Context (BRILL, 2022), 256.



Image 11: 'Habbiyat' silver bracelet with engraving "May you be blessed with joy in health and happiness" "ملبوس الهنا بالصحة والسرور" Made in Jerusalem by the late silversmith Khalil Salman.



Image 12: Zoom in of a silver head-chain, with colourful beads, a glass eye 'awayneh' and small hands called 'khamasiyat' pointing down to symbolize both protection and abundance. Made in Bethlehem in the 1920's.



Image 13: Silver necklace of a fish pendant and hanging bells. Made in the early 20th century.

Out of the earthly

“In her absence I created her image: out of the earthly”[34] —— "في غيابها, كَوَّنْتُ صُورَتَها: مِنَ الأَرضِي"

In the first line of Mahmoud Darwish's poem, his lover symbolises Palestine. In her absence, he reconstructs her image from fragments of memory, mirroring my experience with the scarcity of the presence of Palestinian material culture. The phrase "out of the earthly" resonates with me as I work with clay, embodying this metaphor through my practice of making. By integrating design and making, I use clay as a medium to connect head, hand, heart, and eye.

Through ceramic processes and making, I explore how I can reclaim heritage and to what extent that can nourish my sense of belonging by reconnection with heritage and all the knowledge it holds. Using the adaptability of clay I explore the possibility of creating objects exploring the world of Palestinian jewellery and amulets, building on the heritage to honour the past, inspire the present, and pave the way for a future. Anchoring myself in the wisdom and ancestral knowledge, I aspire to create these objects as an authentic contemporary expression of my indigenous culture, recognizing a current lack and absence of such contemporary expressions and interpretations, with a vision for a future where these traditions find continuity and are celebrated.

Considering the wealth of the cultural heritage, I wish to make the cultural material, jewellery and amulets accessible to people today, offering them as a resource of knowledge and resilience to reclaim spiritual and cultural belonging. This resource, I believe, is a container and an expression of identity as it holds and communicates knowledge, beliefs and values of individuals and communities. In other words, they are the material expression of values. The significance of this resource today is that it could alleviate the sense of alienation by providing an opportunity to bridge the known to the unknown, the past to the present and the material to the immaterial. In that way, it could become a resource of resilience rather than a source of grief of the nostalgic past, destruction and loss. This resource is activated through my making, as it becomes physical and accessible. By transforming cultural objects into contemporary tangible forms, they are brought into the present and made available for engagement. Through direct interaction—whether by touch, recreation, or storytelling—these objects provide knowledge and strengthen cultural continuity. In doing so, they allow reflection, connection, and resilience, ensuring they remain relevant and accessible to a wide audience.

When I work with clay, there’s an inherent thought that stays with me: ceramics hold a permanence that other materials don’t. Unlike metal, which can be melted down and repurposed, or wood, which can decay, ceramics persist. Once fired, they are fixed in their form, unyielding to time and transformation. This resilience reflects a hope I have for my culture.



Image 14: Gaza black ware 1900’s



Image 15: Gaza black ware today

[34] Mahmoud Darwish, “In Her Absence I Created Her Image,” in The Butterfly’s Burden (2008).

For my ceramic making I use a black slip that I prepare myself at Konstfack's workshop, the same slip I used back home, a recipe that I obtained after months of persistent contact with a seller back home, who eventually agreed to share it with me (see image 19 of my black clay on the following page). Although it is not a local material, and the clay has no local connection to Palestine, it carries a personal connection and its deep black color resembles the black Gaza ware and serves as my reinterpretation of the traditional black/grey Gaza ceramic ware This choice grounds my making, even when physically distant from my home and from a city I've never stepped foot in.

The black/grey ware of Gaza achieves its distinctive color through a traditional reduction firing process. After the clay is shaped and dried, the surface is burnished to enhance its smoothness. The pieces are then fired in a kiln or pit using organic materials like wood, straw, or animal dung. During firing, the kiln is sealed to limit oxygen, creating a reduction atmosphere that allows the clay to absorb carbon from the smoke, turning it a deep black. The black pottery of Gaza stands out as one of the few crafts and techniques that have remained unchanged for centuries, kept safe from external influences. This traditional process and technique has remained unchanged for centuries (see images 14 and 15 on previous page). I choose to work with this black clay, even though my firing process differs from traditional methods. While the techniques may vary, the rich black color still resonates with the pottery of Gaza, carrying with it a connection to a tradition that transcends the way it is fired.

I find the historical objects that inspire my work in archives, museums, and private collections, building a library of material references that guide my exploration and learning. Through my making, I reinterpret these objects, breathing life into them and creating opportunities for us to reconnect with them. I collect images to study the objects closely, and deconstruct them to understand their individual elements. From there, I reconstruct a single element using 3D software, printing it to bring it into a tangible form, giving it a new form and context.

My method starts with deconstructing the jewellery piece, allowing me to break it down into its fundamental components, a way to unlock insights, allowing me to understand the object on multiple levels beyond its immediate appearance or function. Through this process, I reinterpret the designs, exploring their significance and translating them into a new context. I then reconstruct objects that are no longer functional jewellery, using clay as my material, allowing them to transform into new forms that maintain a connection to the past while speaking to contemporary meanings.

The first piece I started making (image 5), titled Al-Zard, is inspired by a traditional silver chain used in Palestinian necklaces, head chains and face veils (see image 8 and 12). In these pieces, the chain often serves as a connector or support for pendants or hanging ornaments, rarely receiving attention on its own. I couldn't find any written sources that confirm that the name of this chain is Al-Zard but I got this information from a store owner in the old city of Jerusalem that owns jewellery pieces that contain this chain. I chose to shift that focus, elevating the chain itself as the central element rather than the element it holds, recognizing its strength in being a carrier and its intricate craftsmanship. I construct the chain by extruding coils of clay, letting them settle and take form within a mold. Once the clay reaches the right stiffness, I connect each pair of links, building one link upon another—each link built upon the one before it. There is power in this act of making, in connecting with ancestors through the tangible reconstruction of their adornments.

This chain can only be made by adding one link at a time, much like the passage of time. It grows slowly, embodying the spirit of my making, which, like this chain, builds upon the past. The chain, often overlooked in favor of the pendants, becomes a symbol of connection, continuity, and strength. Shaping each link, I participate as a link myself, drawing inspiration from those who came before me and carrying Palestinian heritage forward, one connection at a time. Through this process, Al Zard embodies the continuity of Palestinian history celebrated in new forms and the active role of craft in expanding it for the future.



Image 16: molds



Image 17: molds with clay coils



Image 18: fired chain

The second work (image 19) consists of fish made from clay using slip-casting techniques, a reinterpretation of traditional Palestinian silver fish pendant worn as a necklace (see image 13). The fish's symbolism is tied to the biblical story of Jesus feeding the multitude with two fish and five loaves of bread—a miracle from the city of Tabgha, symbolizing generosity and abundance. In the context of Palestinian material culture, the fish served as an amulet for abundance and protection. While one fish is enough to symbolize abundance, I have chosen to create many—deliberately rejecting scarcity in favor of plenitude. This abundance reflects my aspiration for Palestinian material culture: not to be preserved in isolation or fragments but to exist abundantly, accessible and celebrated.

The fish lay in a large glass bowl, evoking hospitality, a central aspect of Palestinian culture. It reminds me of bowls of fruit or chocolates placed out in our homes for guests—you instantly know they're meant for you, a generous gesture of offering and welcome. Through this piece, I hope to evoke that same feeling. I aim to return the culture to the people, extending an invitation for everyone to reclaim, connect with, and have access to heritage in its plentitude. To take from it and make it their own.

Another piece I have been working with is a pair of silver bracelets, called 'Habiyyat', (see image 12) made in Jerusalem and usually worn in pairs, one on each wrist in the central hills of Palestine. The bracelets are made of silver spherules arranged in rows and connected to one another by rings and pins. An Arabic inscription offering protection and wishing good health - "May you wear it with joy in good health and well-being" appears engraved onto the clasps of both bracelets, enclosed within an engraved frame of branches. (See images 23, 24 and 25 on following page)



Image 19: Ceramic fish in a bowl (stoneware, 2024)

To explore it, I engage in another act of deconstruction and reconstruction. I began by designing the individual pieces using 3D software, a process where I really had to zoom in and understand all the details and design, that revealed just how intricate and skilled the original design truly is. Recreating it digitally allowed me to appreciate every detail, I was fascinated to understand its proportions, rhythms, and functionality. Through this act, I've come to know the piece not just as a finished object but as a process of decisions, techniques, and intentions. From there, I 3D printed the pieces and made around 20 plaster molds to create the 88 individual components needed for the final piece. I found myself choosing to make the pieces in a scale where each piece individually fits in the palm of my hand, creating a feeling of intimacy and connection. The repetitive slip casting process mirrored the care and intention that must have gone into the original creations. This process of creation became an act of connection—with the past, with the object itself, and the written blessings embedded in it. Re-creating something from scratch demands patience, as if the object reveals itself to me over time, trying to find itself, step by step and layer by layer. Each small piece has been cared for, as though it holds a part of me and my collective heritage, inviting a sense of closeness and continuity.

In reflecting the core of my practice in craft and research, I find that the acts of deconstruction, reconstruction, and making allow me to rejuvenate historical objects. In doing so, I let them evolve and resonate with contemporary meaning, reflecting continuity and relevance. Through this process, my making becomes an agent in bridging gaps between material culture and identity, between the known and the unknown. These acts of creation transform heritage, paving a way for Palestinian material culture to become accessible, celebrated, and alive. Through my hands, heritage is re-formed and continued.



Image 20: casted molds



Image 21: fired pieces



Image 22: assembled pieces

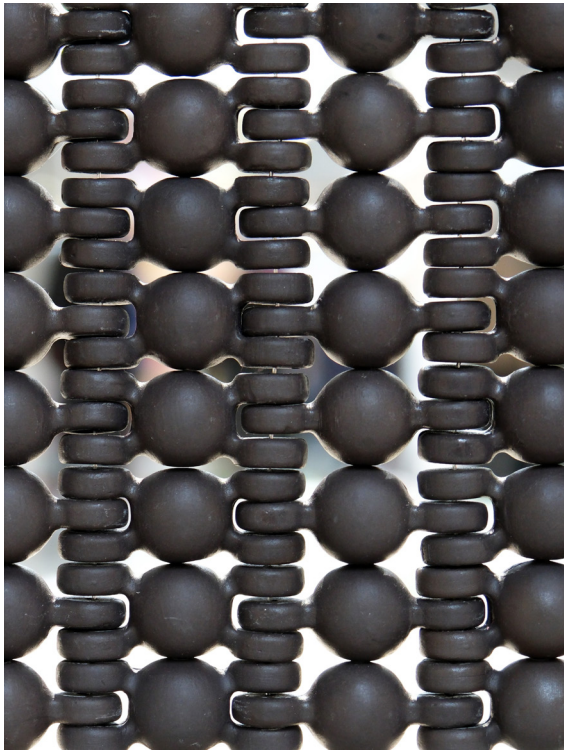


Image 23: zoom in of 'Habbiyat' ceramic beads/seeds.



Image 24: Habbiyat ceramic bracelet, with inscription and lock. Stoneware and glaze.



Image 25: zoom in of 'Habbiyat' ceramic clasp and lock inscribed "May you be blessed with joy " "ملبوس الهنا"

Conclusion

In my research of Palestinian material culture, I have explored the intersection of craft, identity, and cultural heritage through the reclamation and reinterpretation of Palestinian jewellery and amulets. By engaging with these objects, as living, evolving expressions of cultural knowledge, I have sought to reclaim them as resources for resilience, belonging, and identity by transforming them into living expressions of contemporary relevance. This journey embodies the potential of craft to bridge the past and present, offering a way to carry cultural identity forward.

Through processes of deconstruction, reconstruction, and making, I have aimed to rekindle historical objects, creating contemporary expressions of material culture that then become active participants in the ongoing narrative of Palestinian identity ensuring their relevance for present times. This work highlights how material culture serves as both a testament to the resilience of Palestinian identity and a medium for envisioning and shaping meaningful futures. In crafting new interpretations of traditional forms, I have aspired to create objects that resonate with today's realities while honoring the rich knowledge they draw upon.

Ultimately, this research asserts that heritage is not a static inheritance but an active, participatory process of identity formation. By treating heritage as "in the making," it becomes a source of resilience, addressing the aspirations of the present and future.

I have also underscored the role of craft and making as acts of resilience and endurance in a context where cultural heritage is systematically erased, the act of creating becomes a powerful tool for reclaiming agency and identity. Through my practice of working with clay, I have found a medium that embodies both permanence and adaptability. The practice of crafting, becomes an embodiment of endurance—sustaining people while linking generations through material expressions of values, beliefs, and practices. By reconstructing and reinterpreting these objects, I activate and actively engage with Palestinian cultural heritage. In doing so, this work seeks to contribute to a broader understanding of Palestinian cultural heritage as a vibrant, abundant, and transformative force—one that continues to inspire.

Through this work, I hope to have demonstrated the power of craft and material culture to sustain and celebrate identity, offering a vision of a heritage that is abundant, accessible and a resource for resilience. My work aspires to celebrate Palestinian heritage, shaping a future where it is abundant, celebrated, and carried on.



Image 26: Palestinian women carrying water jars from Elisha's spring, Jericho, 1970.

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Images

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Appendix

Reflecting on the process of my master's, I see my journey more clearly now: I see where the personal meets the collective, and I can trace the thread that guides my practice. For the first time, I can define it, this connection between the individual and the collective, the fragment and the whole, and how my work brings them together through making.

This process culminated in the examination exhibition, where I included a book as part of the installation, something I tried for the first time, and I think it worked well. The book became a bridge between my personal research and the audience. It created a space for the archives I engage with closely in my creative process, moving them from the personal digital realm into the collective physical world, where they can be accessed, experienced, and explored by others. The book invites people to understand my work and explore the context and histories I embody as a maker and artist. It opens a space for curiosity, exploration and connection. You can find the book in the Konstfack library, where it is available for those interested in engaging further with my research.

One of the biggest shifts in my practice during the end of the second year was realizing that my focus on material culture—objects, jewellery, amulets—had been so strong, especially with a design background that understands the world through objects, that I almost forgot about the people and contexts to which these objects belong. I had kept my relationship with archives very private, treating them as personal references. But through this process, I learned how to share them: to create archival connections that live beyond me. The book I created became a form of communication that does not rely on my presence in the room. It can speak for itself, and I believe this is an important step forward.

The examination was a valuable space for reflection. Discussions focused on the way I work in clay, how precise and controlled my process is. This helped me understand that my approach is intentional, and that precision is necessary when working with collective cultural material. As it goes beyond me, it's about a culture that has been fragmented, disrupted, and erased over time, one that I belong to and others belong to as well. I cannot take liberties with it. I need to be precise and respectful, and I am okay with the fact that my work is deliberate, slow, and thoughtful. It's a responsibility I hold, and I see it as integral to my practice.

The Spring Exhibition offered an important moment of connection. For the first time, I had visitors from Palestine, professors from Birzeit University, and also Palestinians from the diaspora who live in Sweden, many of whom had never been to Palestine. It was exciting for me to see their reactions. What stood out was that Palestinians from different places, whether from Palestine or the diaspora, were equally interested, engaged, and fascinated by the cultural material my work presents. In these moment I understood even more that I am not the only one who experiences a sense of inaccessibility to Palestinian culture and heritage. There is a shared hunger to connect with our cultural identity, our objects, and our stories. It became clear to me that my work creates a space where we can connect, learn about ourselves and each other, and explore a shared sense of belonging.

This experience strengthened my understanding of the role my work plays: it is not about giving answers or telling a single story. It is about creating a space where people can encounter this rich heritage, reflect on it, and begin to form their own connections. Through this we can continue the threads of our culture in new ways. My practice offers a space for collective reflection, for shared learning, and for a sense of belonging that transcends borders and generations.

Through all of this, I have gained a better understanding of my practice. I see now that the process I follow—listening, collecting, assembling, and making—has been consistent throughout my work, even if I hadn't fully articulated it before. I have learned that my practice explores how a heritage, fragmented and disrupted by dispossession, destruction, and erasure, can be retrieved and reimagined through contemporary craft. My process begins with listening: to cultural materials, to the land, to the relationships between people and their objects. The work that emerges is neither about preservation nor about reinvention; it is a continuation of collective cultural expression.

Lastly, I am grateful for this learning experience and for all the teachers and professors who have contributed to and supported and guided my work. I have also found a sense of home away from home through this process.

What happens next? I hope to publish my book and my paper, sharing this research more widely. I also hope to find a studio in Jerusalem, to have a physical space where I can continue my practice, create, teach, and connect with others who are seeking ways to engage with the material and their sense of belonging. My step forward is towards grounding my work in the local context.

